

Journal Preparations

IB 514: Scientific Writing

Pre-Submission Review by Friendly Reviewers

Journal
Preparations

Friendly
Reviewers

Final
Formatting

Author
Contributions

Open Science

Preprint
Repositories

Page Charges

Suggesting
Reviewers

Submission
Logistics

Selecting Reviewers

- Avoid/Seek reviewers with strong prior positions on your findings
- Prioritize people who will give *honest* feedback, not reassurance
- Consider who might make a better journal reviewer

Briefing Reviewers

- State the target journal and audience
- Set a realistic deadline (2-3 weeks is standard)
- Clarify what kind of feedback is useful: structure, argument, clarity, or all three
- Identify specific concerns you want addressed

Thank them by name in the Acknowledgments.

Consider mentioning in Cover Letter.

Friendly review is *not* a substitute for rigorous self-revision. Send out only when you believe the manuscript is essentially complete.

Final Formatting

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Things I ignore:

- Font type and size
- Margin requirements
- Journal-requested citation format

Things I don't ignore:

- Word/page limits (*incl. title, abstract, main text*)
- Line spacing (*double*) & page numbering
- Figure placement (*inline except if explicitly specified*) and formats (*pdf, tiff, eps*)
- Cover page and/or end-of-manuscript requirements
 - Author contribution and Acknowledgments
 - Conflict of Interest disclosure requirements
 - Data & Code Availability statement requirements

Check:

- Triple-read for spelling and punctuation
- Citation completeness and consistency
- Journal's double-blind requirements

Author Contributions & the CRediT Taxonomy

Journal
Preparations

Purpose

- Distinguish **authorship** from **acknowledgment**
- Increase transparency and accountability
- Expose *ghost authorship* and *gift authorship*
- Increasingly indexed by databases (e.g., OpenAlex)

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The CRediT Taxonomy (14 Roles) credit.niso.org

Conceptualization	Methodology
Data Curation	Project Administration
Formal Analysis	Resources
Funding Acquisition	Software
Investigation	Supervision
Validation	Visualization
Writing — Original Draft	Writing — Review & Editing

Author Contributions Statement

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Common Formats

1 Prose (narrative)

“J.S. conceived the study and led data collection. M.R. performed statistical analysis. . .”

2 Role-tagged list

Conceptualization: J.S., M.R.

Formal Analysis: M.R.

Writing—Original Draft: J.S.

Writing—Review & Editing: All authors

Imperative: Agree on contributions *before drafting*, not retroactively. Disagreements are common, uncomfortable, and potentially costly.¹

¹See *Collaboration* class.

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- Promotes **transparency** and **reproducibility**
- Increases citation impact and research visibility
- Broadens engagement across the research community
- Enhances credibility

Key Considerations

- Article Processing Charges (APCs) can be substantial
- Data sensitivity and participant privacy constraints
- Institutional and funder mandates increasingly require OA

Open Access Paper Publication Models

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Type	Who Pays	Description
Gold	Author / funder	Published OA immediately by the journal; APC required
Green	Nobody	Author self-archives a preprint or accepted manuscript in a repository (e.g., biorXiv)
Diamond	Nobody	Community- or institution-funded; no fees for authors or readers
Hybrid	Author	Subscription journal offers OA for individual articles upon APC payment
Bronze	Nobody	Freely readable on the publisher site <i>without</i> open licence; access can be revoked

Note: Green OA costs nothing and is compatible with most journals. Check policies at <https://openpolicyfinder.jisc.ac.uk>.

Data & Code Sharing

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- Increasingly required by journals and funders
- Can be cited - Digital Object Identifier (DOI)
- Common repositories:
 - Data: Zenodo, FigShare, Data One
 - Code: GitHub, Zenodo
 - Supplementary materials (*no longer considered enough*)
- Best practices:
 - Include comprehensive documentation and README files
 - Provide appropriate licensing

FAIR Data Principles

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FAIR defines standards to maximise reuse and reproducibility.

F — Findable Data are assigned persistent identifiers (e.g., DOIs) and described with rich, searchable metadata.

A — Accessible Data and metadata are retrievable via open, standardised protocols; access conditions are clearly stated.

I — Interoperable Data use common formats, vocabularies, and ontologies to enable integration with other datasets and tools.

R — Reusable Data carry explicit licences (e.g., CC BY) and sufficient provenance information for others to build on them.

Full guidelines at go-fair.org/fair-principles.

Note: FAIR does not require data to be *open* — sensitive data can be FAIR with controlled access.

Preprint Repositories: Examples

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bioRxiv Life sciences; operated by Cold Spring Harbor Laboratory; the dominant biology preprint server since 2013.

EcoEvoRxiv Ecology and evolutionary biology; community-governed; supports registered reports and post-publication versions.

arXiv Physics, mathematics, computer science, quantitative biology; the oldest major preprint server (est. 1991); moderated by field endorers.

Zenodo General-purpose; accepts preprints, datasets, code, and presentations; assigns DOIs; widely used for open science compliance.

Authorea Collaborative writing and preprint platform; supports live figures, data embedding, and inline commenting; blurs the boundary between manuscript and publication.

Preprint Repositories: Primary Pros & Cons

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Advantages

- **Speed:** findings are public immediately, months before formal publication
- **Priority:** timestamped record of contribution
- **Visibility:** indexed by Google Scholar, etc.
- **Feedback:** community comments before peer review
- **Open access:** freely available
- **Funder compliance:** satisfies some open science mandates immediately

Disadvantages

- **Journal policies:** some journals discourage or prohibit
- **No peer review:** errors and weak claims are public
- **Perception:** some fields and hiring committees do not credit preprints
- **Retraction gap:** flawed preprints may persist even after journal rejection
- **Media risk:** premature press coverage before validation

Peer Community In... (PCI)

PeerCommunityIn.org

Goals

- Transparent peer review *before* (or *instead of*) journal submission
- Eliminate fees for authors and readers
- Reduce dependence on commercial publishers

How It Works

- Authors submit preprint (e.g., to bioRxiv), then request PCI review
- Volunteer recommender (acting editor) solicits and coordinates reviews
- Accepted preprints receive a **PCI Recommendation** — citable endorsement
- PCI-friendly journals accept recommended preprints, or regular review

PCI Animal Science
PCI Archaeology
PCI Ecology
PCI Ecotox Env Chem
PCI Evol Biol
PCI Forest Wood Sci
PCI Genomics
PCI Health Mov Sci
PCI Infections
PCI Math Comp Biol
PCI Microbiology
PCI Network Science
PCI Neuroscience
PCI Nutrition
PCI Org Studies
PCI Paleontology
PCI Plants
PCI Psychology
PCI Registered Reports
PCI Statistics and
Machine Learning
PCI Zoology

Page Charges & Publication Fees

Journal
Preparations

- **Article Processing Charges (APCs):** \$500–\$12,000+ depending on journal/OA model
- **Page charges:** \$0–\$200 per printed page for subscription journals
- **Color figure fees:** \$300–\$1,000+ per figure; often free online-only

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Who Pays — and How to Find Out

- **Ask your advisor first:** most PIs budget for publication costs through grants; this is a normal conversation to have
- **Institutional waivers:** many universities (but not OSU!) have OA publishing funds; check with library
- **Funder mandates:** NIH, Wellcome Trust, and others *require* OA and may cover fees directly
- **Request a waiver:** most journals offer hardship waivers for authors without funding — ask before assuming you must pay

Bottom line: You shouldn't be expected to pay out of pocket. Clarify funding *before* submission, not after acceptance.

Suggesting Potential Reviewers

How to Identify

- Researchers who publish directly on topic or methods
- Authors cited in manuscript (but not exclusively)
- Individuals with complementary expertise (theory, methods, system)

Who to Avoid

- Current or recent collaborators (typically last 3–5 years)
- Members of your institution or close professional network
- Advisors, committee members, or mentors

Strategic Considerations

- Aim for 4–8 suggested reviewers
- Ensure diversity (perspectives, institutions, career stage, gender)
- Avoid suggesting only highly favorable reviewers

Opposed Reviewers

- Allowed by some journals but use very sparingly and justify!²

²Consider use as "friendly" reviewer

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Explore your target journal's submission system!